

The tripartite Agricultural Workforce Forum (the Forum) was established in September 2023 to build on the work of the former Agricultural Workforce Working Group. The Forum's main goal is to find practical solutions to workforce issues in the agriculture and meat processing sectors.

The Forum focuses on:

- building collaborative, three-way partnerships between government, industry and unions
- advocating for the interests of the sector in important workforce issues and priorities
- engaging with key government departments to shape decisions and outcomes
- working with key partners to identify workforce needs and respond effectively.

The Forum brings together a diverse range of views to ensure worker and business needs are heard. The Forum meets several times a year, including out-of-session discussions.

The Forum is chaired by the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and is attended by Senator the Hon Anthony Chisholm, Assistant Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

Forum members include representatives from:

- National Farmers' Federation
- Australian Council of Trade Unions
- National Farmers' Federation Horticulture Council
- Australian Fresh Produce Alliance
- Australian Workers' Union
- Australian Dairy Farmers
- United Workers Union
- Australian Meat Industry Council
- Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union

Mr John Azarias, independent public policy expert, is also a member of the Forum. Representatives from Skills Insight have a standing invite to attend meetings as observers.

Agricultural Workforce Working Group

The tripartite Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) was established in October 2022 by the then Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt. It brought together government, industry and unions to work on shared workforce issues.

During its operation from October 2022 – September 2023, the Working Group focused on ways to attract, skill, protect and retain workers in agriculture and processing sectors.

Key achievements included:

- influential advocacy for fee-free TAFE courses in agriculture, the Food Supply Chain Capacity Study, and the Ag Trade Apprenticeship Project

- supporting new rules for labour hire licensing, considered by the Commonwealth Minister for Employment and Workplace Relations
- representing agriculture in major national processes such as the Migration Review and the Employment White Paper.

In the final Working Group meeting on 15 September 2023, the Working Group agreed to continue tripartite engagement through the new Agricultural Workforce Forum.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/workforce-support>